Epilogue

PTI and the Disillusioned 'Naya' Pakistan: One Year On

A year into PTI's government, Pakistan has gone back to the International Monetary Fund (IMF) for the thirteenth time in thirty-one years. As the government struggles with a collapsing economy, further budget cuts have been introduced to education and health. The elected members of the National Assembly, Mohsin Dawar and Ali Wazir, who were associated with a predominantly peaceful PTM movement, have been arrested and accused of instigating an attack by PTM protestors on an army checkpoint in Waziristan. Media outlets and journalists are facing unprecedented censorship, as news channels have intermittently been forced to go off air for showing interviews of opposition leaders or discussions related to the PTM. One year on, the pretence of human rights that was a key part of Prime Minister Imran Khan's inaugural speech seems to have been abandoned, with the security state stronger than ever before as the interests of both the civilian government and the military clearly align.

Imran Khan had promised Pakistan would not resort to the IMF but with a foreign debt burden of more than US$105 billion, and a current account deficit that 'reached a peak level of $19 billion in 2017–18' (Pasha et al. 2019), the country has had to accept the new structural adjustment plan of the IMF which will result in more welfare cuts, unemployment and inflation (See Shalal 2019; BBC News 2019). The promise of quality education and opportunity to the youth of the country will be far from fulfilled as the budget expenditure reveals severe cuts in education, with Rs. 77,262 million provided in budget estimates from 2019–20, against Rs. 97,420 million in budget estimates for 2018–19, and Rs. 97,155 million in revised estimates for 2018–19 (see Government of Pakistan 2019). The Higher Education Commission has been bracing for budget cuts nearing 50 per cent in its development expenditure. These cuts will particularly impact scholarship students from the most vulnerable parts of the country. Along with a weakening economy and rising inflation, unemployment figures